matters, then we must play the caste game better than others,' was Shah's message to the booth-level workers.

I had a first-hand experience of Shah's caste calculations during the BJP's ticket distribution exercise. An office colleague came to me with a strange request. 'Sir, there is a friend of mine from UP. She is an MLA there and is very keen to meet you, she needs your help.'

An hour later, an astute young politician called Anupriya Patel, who was the sitting MLA from the Ruhaniya assembly seat of Varanasi, was in my cabin. She was from the Kurmi-dominated Apna Dal party which had been started by her late father, Sonelal Patel. 'Sir, I need a favour. Could you fix an appointment for me with Mr Shah? I wish to contest the elections in alliance with the BJP,' she said, with refreshing candour.

I wasn't quite sure how to react. As an editor, I had determinedly stayed out of the murky world of political wheeling and dealing. 'Look, I will request Amitbhai to meet you, but please understand, I am no great friend of his and I am not going to ask him to give you a ticket!' was my immediate response.

Hesitantly, I called up Shah. His reaction was instant: *'Please, aap unhe Gujarat Bhavan bhej do'* (Send her to Gujarat Bhavan). A few days later, I got a call from Ms Patel. 'Thank you so much, sir, my ticket is done. Our alliance with the BJP is sealed!' The Apna Dal was given two seats, both of which they would eventually win. I guess in my small way, almost unintentionally, I had contributed to the BJP success in UP!

I asked Shah later why he had decided to tie up with the Apna Dal, a party with a limited presence in a tiny pocket of eastern Uttar Pradesh. *'Isme chhote bade ki baat nahi hai, yahan har seat matter karti hai. Unke Kurmi samaj ka teen–char per cent vote hai'* (It's not a question of big or small. Every seat matters. The Kurmis have a 3 to 4 per cent vote in these areas), he claimed. The final BJP list for UP would include twenty-eight OBCs and seventeen non-Jatav Dalits.

Shah, with his astute planning, may have been the mind behind the UP campaign. But he still needed the 'face' of Modi to guarantee success. 'We wanted to project Modiji as the symbol of good governance and contrast the